

- **FileZilla:** FileZilla is an FTP client that basically lets you connect to a server that has FTP access enabled. Once connected, it lets you upload and download files and directory structures. It can also perform basic actions like changing the file attributes.

FileZilla can handle multiple transfer threads at the same time. This is especially helpful if you are transferring a lot of little files. It also has a nice keep-alive function that will keep your FTP connection open and available. Since most Web hosts will close the connection after a couple of minutes of no activity, this will prevent no end of frustration if you are making a bunch of little tweaks and changes on your site.

One gripe with FileZilla is that you cannot have simultaneous connections to multiple servers. I sometimes find this necessary while developing websites, and the only option is to get the files required to the local machine and then move them to the other server. But it is quite cumbersome, and this feature is absolutely desirable.

- **Browsers (Firefox, Opera, IE, Google Chrome):** Yes, I have been booting into Windows pretty regularly. Why? Because IE_s4Linux proved to be inaccurate in rendering the site's CSS and it was important for me to know how the site fared on IE 6, 7 and 8. Moreover, despite the presence of the open source Webkit-based browser called Arora, it is very basic compared to Chrome and Safari. So I did need the afore-mentioned browsers to test the usability, look and navigability of LinuxForU.com.

Webmaster tools

- **FeedBurner:** As far as RSS goes, FeedBurner is the hottest feed management technology. If you thought RSS was powerful before, it's ten times as useful when powered by their proprietary tracking and enhancement technologies. When you sign up for FeedBurner, you give it your RSS

feed's address, and FeedBurner gives you a new feed address to replace it with. When people subscribe to your new FeedBurner address, the service starts tracking subscriptions. This process is called 'burning your feed'. To learn more about FeedBurner and RSS feeds, check out technosailor.com/2006/11/29/review-of-feedburner.

- **Google Webmaster tools:** This is a must if you want your site to be optimised for Google's search algorithm. It will tell you when the last Google crawler visit occurred, what kind of errors are encountered in your website, and the most important is your 'prefer domain'. Google Web master tools are free to use, which was a wonderful surprise—that Google actually came up with this tool to make the Web master's life easier.

If you often wonder why you didn't do too well in Google's ranking, this tool might help you to detect the problem. Anyway, it works fine but still lacks some important features. We encountered some trouble figuring out what had caused the errors in our website, and there was not much assistance to fix the errors other than just showing the error messages. For future releases, we hope this tool will become more intelligent and help us, step by step, in solving issues that may crop up.

- **Google Analytics:** Google Analytics is one of the best tools out there for analysing traffic on your website. With a little bit of setting up, it will give you an enormous amount of information about who is coming to your site, what they're looking for, and how they're getting there. In fact, it has so much information that it can be overwhelming! Google Analytics shows you how people found your site, how they explored it, and how you can enhance their visitor experience. With this information, you can improve the return on investment of your website and increase conversions. (Check out

en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Google_Analytics for more information.)

Plug-ins incorporated!

Plug-ins are a great way to extend the functionality of anything, be it your desktop application, a device hardware or even a CMS. One of the major reasons the open source CMSs became popular was their capability of being extended effortlessly and without any programming knowledge, just by using plug-ins. Yes, even LinuxForU.com uses quite a few plug-ins, a lot more than what I'd have liked. Allow me to list the most important ones here and also mention why we installed them.

- **Advanced Excerpt:** This plug-in extends the functionality of the default `wp_excerpt()` function by allowing you to specify the character length for the excerpts and also the addition of HTML markups.
- **CommentLuv:** This plug-in has been used to show a link to the last post from the commenters' blog by parsing the feed at their given URL when they leave a comment. This was what we came up with when we wondered what more could be offered to a commenter!
- **Editor Extender:** Despite the default TinyMCE editor of WordPress being pretty feature-rich, it lacked the capability to create tables. This was achieved by 'extending' the functionality of WordPress' default editor using this plug-in.
- **Live Comment Preview:** A lot of us use HTML tags while commenting on a blog and more often than not end up using the preview feature just to make sure the comment looks the way we want it to. Well, we just made life easier for you and provided you with a live preview of whatever you want to write to us about. Happy commenting!
- **Most Commented:** We have three tabs at the sidebar, one of which sorts the articles on the basis of the number of comments received. This helps in featuring popular content